Philosophy · Epistemology · What is knowledge?

The Gettier Puzzle

A companion workbook for the lesson 'The Gettier puzzle and no false lemma'. Use it alongside the slides: read, fill in, map, then write.

The tripartite view says that knowledge is **justified true belief** (JTB). Edmund Gettier produced examples that appear to be justified, true belief that still does **not** count as knowledge. In doing so he 'opened up' a search for a better definition. This workbook takes you through that puzzle step by step.

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Part 01 The starting point

The tripartite view (JTB)

On the tripartite view, a person knows that P if, and only if, three conditions are met. Each condition is meant to be **necessary**, and together they are meant to be **sufficient**.

Key Thesis · The tripartite view

(1) P is true. **(2)** P is believed. **(3)** P is justified.

If all three are met, the belief counts as knowledge.

Two important assumptions: the principle of closure

To see how the Gettier puzzle works, you need the principle of closure (slide 3):

1. If I know that P,
2. and I know that P implies Q,
3. then, given P, I am justified in believing Q.

Key idea Closure lets justification 'travel' from one belief to another that follows from it. Gettier relies on this to show Smith's conclusion is justified.

Check your understanding

Task *Answer in one or two sentences each.*

1. What are the three conditions of the tripartite view?

1. In your own words, what does the principle of closure allow us to do?

Part 02 The thought experiment

Smith, Jones and the ten coins

1. Smith and Jones are both going for a job interview.
2. Smith is told by a contact that he trusts that Jones will get the job.
3. Smith sees Jones put ten coins in his pocket just before the interview.
4. Smith reasons: 'The man who will get the job has ten coins in his pocket.'
5. Unknown to Smith, he **also** has ten coins in his pocket – and, surprisingly, **Smith** gets the job.

Key idea Smith's belief is justified, true and believed. But it isn't knowledge. Your job is to explain why.

Table 1 · Test Smith's belief against JTB

Task *Belief being tested: 'The man who will get the job has ten coins in his pocket.' Fill in each row.*

Condition	Is it met? (Yes / No)	Evidence from the example
Belief		
Truth		
Justification		
Knowledge?		

Table 2 · Other Gettier-style examples

Task *Slide 6 shows that we can multiply examples. Complete the stopped-clock row, then invent one of your own.*

Example	What is believed?	Why is it J, T and B?	Why is it not knowledge?
Stopped clock			
My own example			

Part 03 Mapping the argument

Gettier's argument as a map

An argument map shows how premises link together to reach a conclusion. Read the boxes from top to bottom. Complete the empty boxes using the slides.

PREMISE 1
Smith believes Jones will get the job.

PREMISE 2
Smith believes Jones has ten coins in his pocket.

SUPPORTING PRINCIPLE
_*Write the principle of closure:*
_____

▼ ▼ ←

INTERMEDIATE CONCLUSION
Ergo, Smith believes that the man who gets the job will have ten coins in his pocket.

SO IT IS...
_*Justified because*
_____

▼

PREMISE 3 (THE TWIST)
_*What actually happens?*_____

▼

INTERMEDIATE CONCLUSION
_*So Smith's belief is J, T and B because*_____

▼

MAIN CONCLUSION
Therefore JTB is not sufficient for knowledge – the tripartite view must be revised.

Task *Underneath the map: which premise is false? Circle it on the map and explain why it matters.*

Part 04

Responding to Gettier

The no false lemma solution

This solution adds a further condition to knowledge, the 'no false lemma' condition. We should not reach our conclusion via a false lemma (premise). In Smith's case, the false lemma is 'Jones will get the job'.

> Key Thesis · No false lemma (JTB + 1)
> A person X knows that P if and only if: **(1)** P is believed; **(2)** P is true; **(3)** P is justified; **AND (4)** P is not inferred from any false proposition.

Henry in barn country

The no false lemma definition does not seem to work. In the 'Henry in barn country' example, Henry:

1. believes he sees a barn;
2. it is true he sees a barn;
3. he has justification that he sees a barn;
4. he has not got it from a false proposition.

Key idea Henry meets all four conditions, yet we still hesitate to say he knows. So JTB + no false lemma is still not sufficient.

Table 3 · Compare the definitions

Task *Tick or cross: does each case meet the definition? Then judge whether it gives the right answer.*

Definition	Smith & Jones	Henry in barn country	Does it survive? Why?
Tripartite (JTB)			
No false lemma (JTB + 4)			
Improved (JTB + 4 + 5)			

Adding a fifth condition – and its problem

We could add another condition: **(5)** if someone is in a strange context, they need to know it (Henry would need to know he is in barn country). The problem is that we could never know we are **not** in a

strange situation. If you were a brain in a vat given a digital simulation of real life, you could never know it.

Task *Explain in your own words why condition (5) seems to set the bar for knowledge too high.*

Part 05 Exam practice

Use the checklists to plan before you write. Short answers reward precision; the 12-mark answers reward a clear, step-by-step explanation.

1. What is meant by the ‘no false lemma’ condition? [3 marks]

Checklist *Give a precise definition in one or two sentences. No example needed.*

2. Explain the no false lemma solution to the tripartite (JTB) definition of knowledge. [5 marks]

Checklist *State the extra condition · explain what it adds to JTB · apply it to Smith and Jones · name the false lemma.*

3. Outline and explain the tripartite theory of knowledge. [12 marks]

Checklist *Define each condition · explain necessary and sufficient · use Gettier's Smith & Jones case to show why JTB is challenged · keep each step linked.*

4. Outline and explain how the 'Henry in barn country' thought experiment can undermine the no false lemma definition. [12 marks]

Checklist *State the no false lemma definition · set out Henry's case · show he meets all four conditions · explain why this undermines the definition · mention the fifth condition and its problem.*

Part 06 Glossary

Term	Meaning
Tripartite view (JTB)	The view that knowledge is justified, true belief.
Justification	Good reason or evidence for holding a belief.
Necessary condition	A condition that must be met for something to count as knowledge.
Sufficient condition	A condition (or set of conditions) that, if met, is enough for knowledge.
Principle of closure	If I know P, and I know P implies Q, then given P I am justified in believing Q.
Gettier puzzle / case	An example of justified, true belief that does not appear to be knowledge.
Lemma	A premise used on the way to a conclusion.
No false lemma	The extra condition that P must not be inferred from any false proposition.
Henry in barn country	A case where Henry meets all four no-false-lemma conditions but seemingly lacks knowledge.
Strange context	An unusual situation (e.g. barn country, a brain in a vat) that undermines a belief without our realising.
Brain in a vat	A scenario where a brain is fed a digital simulation of life and could never tell.

Task *Add any other words you meet in the lesson:*